

MEETING JOB AIDS

GRAB THE CARD YOU NEED. PLAN IT, RUN IT, LAND THE DECISION.

These are **just-in-time tools** — not a course to sit through. Keep them where you meet: pin them by your desk, drop them in your notebook, or paste the templates into your notes app. Each page stands on its own, so print only the one you need.

What's in the pack

1. **Do We Even Need This Meeting?** — the 60-second gate before you send the invite
2. **Agenda-on-a-Page** — a fill-in template that drives to a decision
3. **Run-the-Room Card** — the five moves for landing a decision
4. **What to Actually Say** — a phrase bank for the tricky moments
5. **Close-It-Out / Decision Log** — capture decisions so they stick
6. **The Meeting Cost Check** — what an hour really costs

Anchored to First Things First — Respect (people's time), Team (decisions made together), Integrity (a decision made is a decision kept).

DO WE EVEN NEED THIS MEETING?

Answer two questions before you send the invite:

1. **What decision are we making?** → If you can't name one, send an update, not an invite.
2. **Who owns that decision?** → There should be exactly one decision-maker.

The "who's needed?" test — run every name through it:

ROLE	QUESTION	VERDICT
Decision-maker	Who makes the call? (Exactly one.)	Invite
Must-have input	Can the decision be made without them?	If no → Invite
Must-know	Do they only need the outcome?	Send the notes , not the invite
Everyone else	Any real role in this decision?	Cut

Meeting — or something faster?

IF IT'S...	THEN...
A status / update	Send it in writing; meet only if a decision surfaces
An FYI	Email
"Not sure yet"	Don't hold a meeting to decide whether to hold a meeting
A real decision with an owner	Meet — and keep it small

If no name is the decision-maker, you don't have a meeting. You have an email.

AGENDA-ON-A-PAGE

Meeting: _____ Date / time: _____ Length: _____

Decision-maker: _____

The decision we owe today: _____

TIME	ITEM — <i>VERB + THE DECISION</i>	OWNER	PRE-READ
___ min	<i>Decide ...</i>		
___ min	<i>Decide ...</i>		
___ min	<i>Approve / revise ...</i>		
___ min	<i>Decide ...</i>		

Parking lot — *captured, not discussed today:*

-
-

Rules of thumb: biggest decision first · a time on every line · send it ahead with the pre-read.

An agenda without a decision is just a to-do list read aloud.

RUN-THE-ROOM CARD

Five moves. Your job isn't to talk the most — it's to **get the decision made**.

#	MOVE	DO THIS
1	Open	Name the decision and how you'll make it: <i>"By 2:30 we'll decide X. Here's how."</i>
2	Time	Keep time out loud. Park the rabbit holes in the parking lot.
3	Dissent	Ask <i>"Who sees it differently?"</i> Silence is not agreement.
4	Decide	Make the call — and say the method: <i>consensus</i> or <i>consult-then-decide</i> .
5	Blocked?	Name what's missing, who gets it, by when. Don't fake a yes.

Before you leave the room: every decision has an **owner** and a **date**, and someone captured it.

Like a coach: run practice, call a play now and then — you don't take every shot.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY SAY

A phrase bank for the moments that derail meetings.

WHEN THIS HAPPENS...	TRY SAYING...
It's drifting into status updates	<i>"That's a status item — let's take it to the notes. The decision we owe today is ____."</i>
Someone's down a rabbit hole	<i>"Good thread — parking lot. Back to the decision."</i>
The room goes quiet	<i>"I can see some hesitation. Who sees this differently?"</i>
Two people are stuck	<i>"I hear both. Here's how I'll make the call..."</i>
You're running long	<i>"We've got five minutes. Let's land the decision and take the rest to notes."</i>
The decision-maker isn't here	<i>"We can't decide this today without _____. Let's set who decides and by when."</i>
Someone reopens a settled decision	<i>"We decided this — here's the record. What's new that would change it?"</i>
Nobody owns a next step	<i>"Who owns this, and by when?"</i>

Naming what's happening — out loud, without blame — is 80% of running the room.

CLOSE-IT-OUT / DECISION LOG

Spend the last five minutes here. Read each decision back. If the room can't restate it, it wasn't decided.

DECISION MADE	OWNER	DUE

Send within 24 hours to: everyone in the room + the must-know list.

Guard the decision: reopen only for genuinely new information — not a second opinion.

A decision nobody wrote down is a decision you'll make again. If a row has no owner or no date, it wasn't decided — fix it before you send.

THE MEETING COST CHECK

A meeting costs **people × time** — whether or not a decision comes out. Before you book it, look at the real number:

PEOPLE	30 MIN	60 MIN
3	1.5 work-hours	3 work-hours
6	3 work-hours	6 work-hours (most of a workday)
10	5 work-hours	10 work-hours

So: the bigger the room, the higher the bar. If you can't name the decision, you can't justify the cost.

Inviting someone isn't respect. Respecting their time is.

Prepared by Vanderpool Consulting, LLC — Library job aids for the Running Effective Meetings course.